

Premise Worksheet

Build the one sentence your whole story hangs on.

01 The four raw materials Fill each box before you try the sentence.

CHARACTER

Who is this about? One vivid, specific detail beats a full biography.

WANT

What do they pursue? Make it concrete enough to photograph.

OBSTACLE

What stands in the way? The best obstacles push back on purpose.

STAKES

What happens if they fail? If nothing changes, nothing matters.

02 Compose the sentence When [character] must [want], they face [obstacle], and if they fail, [stakes].

03 Test it A premise that fails a test is not dead, it is unfinished. Revise and retest.

- ☐ **The conflict is specific.**
Not "struggles with life": a fight you can name, against someone or something.
- ☐ **I can see the shape of an ending.**
The sentence points somewhere. You do not need the ending, only its silhouette.
- ☐ **A stranger would ask "what happens next?"**
Say it to someone who owes you nothing. Curiosity is the whole job.
- ☐ **It fits in one breath.**
Read it aloud. If you need a second inhale, cut until you do not.
- ☐ **The promise is clear.**
A reader can tell what kind of ride they just bought a ticket for.

04 The promise The premise is a contract. Name its terms.

GENRE

TONE, 3 ADJECTIVES
